EXECUTIVE DECK

WPP: Where Humans Stay in the Loop

How can WPP Production turn one approved global campaign into hundreds of market and channel assets, with AI doing the repeatable work and people keeping the judgement calls?

Independent analysis using public information only. Not affiliated with or endorsed by WPP. Model inputs are illustrative.

WHERE WPP STANDS

WPP is cutting costs and rebuilding production while AI tools reshape the agency business

£4.75bn
Revenue less pass-through costs in the first half of 2026. It fell 4.7% on a like-for-like basis.

97,388
People employed at 30 June 2026. A year earlier the figure was 104,083.

£500m
Annual savings that WPP aims for by 2028 under its Elevate28 plan.

5%
Share of income from WPP Production, the new unit that combines the production teams of Hogarth, VML and Ogilvy.

WPP says AI should augment human creativity rather than replace it. Analysts warn that self-service tools from Google, Meta and WPP's own platform could take production work away from agencies.

Sources: WPP results (2025 and first half 2026), eMarketer. Not affiliated with or endorsed by WPP.

THE ANSWER IN BRIEF

Let people approve the rules and a sample, not every single asset

Our recommendation is to sort the work into three lanes, let AI do the repeatable work under written rules, and put four human gates around it. In an illustrative campaign of 480 assets, the central case looks like this.

36%

Less elapsed time

One campaign wave would take 18 working days instead of 28.

27%

Lower cost per asset

Hands-on cost would fall from about £192 to about £140 per asset.

4

Human gates

People decide on the rules, a first sample, brand and legal risk, and the final set.

These are modelled results from illustrative inputs. In a cautious case the gains fall to 21% less time and 8% lower cost.

HOW THE WORK FLOWS TODAY

Today about half of the elapsed time goes to review, approval and rework

One illustrative campaign wave: 480 assets, for 20 markets, 6 channels and 4 versions each. It takes 28 working days.



Brand and legal review

Three days of review, followed by one day of rework.

Client review

Two rounds and final approval take eight days, plus three days of rework.

Rework

About one asset in three is changed after a review, and each change costs hands-on time.

A 2026 survey of 388 US marketers found that 46% say content gets stuck in review and 41% say it stalls in approvals. Our split of days is an assumption built to fit that signal, so the model also tests a case where review is only 27% of the delay.

Sources: PhotoShelter survey via CMOtech UK (a vendor survey); days are our assumptions. Not affiliated with WPP.

WHICH WORK AI CAN DO

Three lanes show where AI can help and where people must decide

LANE 1

AI works under written rules

29% of today's hands-on hours

- AI resizes and reformats assets for every channel.
- AI makes a first-pass translation and subtitles.
- Automated checks test file specifications and brand rules.

LANE 2

AI drafts and people finish

43% of today's hands-on hours

- AI drafts local copy and a person edits it.
- AI generates image and video variants and an artist finishes them.
- AI consolidates feedback and a producer decides what to change.

LANE 3

People decide

9% of today's hands-on hours

- A lawyer checks every claim and rights question.
- A local reviewer checks cultural fit in sensitive markets.
- A brand reviewer and the client give the final sign-off.

Rework takes the remaining 19% of hours. The scores behind the lanes are our judgement, and we tested them by moving every score up and down by one point.

THE OPTIONS

Three options were scored, and the redesigned workflow came out ahead

Option A

Bolt-on AI tools

2.85

AI speeds up the making of assets, but review stays exactly as it is, so the timeline barely moves.

Option B, recommended

Three lanes and four human gates

3.70

AI does repeatable work under rules, and review moves earlier and becomes selective.

Option C

Platform-led self-service

3.20

Clients create assets themselves on a platform. It is the fastest and cheapest, but weakest on brand safety and legal risk.

Scores are out of 5 across six weighted criteria and are our judgement. Option B stays first with equal weights and when any single score moves by one point. Option C would win only if speed and cost together carried about 60% of the weight, compared with 40% in our base case.

Sources: our scoring, informed by Forrester and 4As survey, eMarketer, MediaPost. Not affiliated with WPP.

THE RECOMMENDED DESIGN

Four human gates sit around the AI work and bring it down to 18 days

The campaign moves through five stages, and the working days are our design target against 28 days today.

Set the rules	Prove the pattern	Produce and check	Client approval	Deliver
3 days	3 days	7 days, including 1 of rework	4 days, including 1 of rework	1 day

Gate 1

Brief and brand rules locked

The client signs the brand rules and the rules for using AI before any production starts.

Gate 2

First sample approved

The client approves a small sample set, so the pattern is settled while changes are still cheap.

Gate 3

Brand and legal check passed

Reviewers check every high-risk item and a sample of the rest.

Gate 4

Client approves the final set

The client reviews high-risk items and a sample, with one round of changes included.

One critical error found in a sample widens the check to the whole batch, and anyone at a gate can stop the line.

WHAT THE MODEL SHOWS

The central case saves 27% of the cost per asset and 36% of the elapsed time

One campaign wave of 480 assets	Cautious	Central	Optimistic	Bolt-on tools
Cost per asset, change	−8%	−27%	−50%	−10%
Elapsed time, change	−21%	−36%	−50%	−7%
Working days per wave	22	18	14	26
Net cost saved a year, at 60 waves	£0.44m	£1.51m	£2.79m	£0.57m
Months to repay the one-off cost	54	9.6	3.9	not modelled

Time and cost come from different places

About 70% of the days saved come from fewer review loops. About 77% of the hours saved come from automating repeatable work.

Volume decides whether it pays

At 10 waves a year, even the central case takes about 57 months to repay the one-off cost.

RISK AND CONTROL

Human control is built into the rules, and money is released only when results are shown

The four biggest risks

- A brand error could reach the market. The risk score is 15 of 25 before actions and 8 after.
- An unapproved claim or a rights problem could slip through. The score is 15, falling to 8.
- Clients could refuse to approve patterns and samples. The score is 12, falling to 6.
- AI could save less time than assumed. The score is 12, falling to 9.

Three rules at every checkpoint

- Continue if elapsed time is at least 25% shorter, critical errors are no higher and clients accept sampling.
- Re-scope if the time saving is between 10% and 25%.
- Stop if critical errors rise, clients reject sampling or the saving is under 10%.

The thresholds are our assumptions and are agreed before the pilot starts.

Every item in Lane 3 is checked by a person, AI does not sign anything off, and every AI-made asset is logged so it can be traced.

Scores are our judgement; 15 risks are rated in the full register. Not affiliated with or endorsed by WPP.

THE DECISION

Start with one pilot wave and let the checkpoints decide the rest

Weeks 0 to 4
Prepare
£0.2m
Measure the baseline and write the rules.

Weeks 5 to 16
Pilot
£0.4m
Run one live wave through the gates.

Months 4 to 8
Extend
£0.4m
Add three to five clients with enough volume.

Months 9 to 12
Scale
£0.2m
Make it the standard route for suitable work.

What we ask for

Approve the first stage only, at an illustrative £0.2m. Later money is released only if the stop rules are met.

What would change this advice

- Giving speed and cost about 60% of the weight would favour self-service.
- A baseline wave showing review is under 35% of the delay would weaken the case.
- Clients refusing sampling would reduce the design to option A.

Illustrative figures; WPP publishes no production hours or savings. Sources are in the Source Log. Not affiliated with WPP.